1

GROWTH · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Show Up ANYWAY

Motivation[1] comes and goes.
Habits[2] stick around.
Make it so small[3]
you can't talk yourself out of it,
then show up anyway.[4]

1 January hype is gone by Feb.
2 Same time, same place, every day.
3 Ten push-ups. One page. Start there.
4 Never miss twice in a row.

2

GAME DAY · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Bad CALL

Refs miss[1] calls.
You can't change[2] it.
You control[3] the next play.
Reset[4] in one breath,
and let your game do the talking.

1 So do players. So do you.
2 Arguing just earns you a technical.
3 Eyes up. Find your man. Go.
4 Touch your laces. Back in.

SPEAK UP · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Say It IN PERSON

Hard[1] conversations
don't belong in a text.[2]
Say it face to face,[3]
calm[4] and direct.
It's harder, and it works better.

1 Conflicts, apologies, bad news.
2 Tone gets lost. Screenshots last forever.
3 Or a call, at minimum.
4 Wait until you've cooled off.

SCHOOL · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Study SMARTER

Rereading[1] feels productive.
Testing[2] yourself works.
Space[3] it out over days,
teach[4] it to someone,
and sleep before the test.

1 Highlighting is mostly decoration.
2 Close the book. Write what you know.
3 20 min a day beats one all-nighter.
4 Explain it to your sister.

5

FEELINGS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Stress Can Be FUEL

A little stress[1] helps.
It sharpens[2] you up.
Too much?[3] Shrink the list.
Move,[4] sleep, and talk it out.
Stress is fuel when you steer it.

1 Fast heart means fuel is on the way.
2 Treat it like pregame nerves.
3 Write every task down. Pick one.
4 Run around for ten minutes.

6

SCHOOL · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Grades Are DATA

A grade is data.[1]
It shows what you know[2]
and what to work on[3] next.
Bad grade?[4] Ask why.
You are more than a number.

1 Which topics cost you points?
2 Circle what you got right too.
3 Pick one topic. Fix it this week.
4 Tell us before we see it online.

7

FRIENDS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Crush CODE

Got a crush? [1] Normal.

Be honest [2] and kind.

If it's a no, [3] take it well.

Keep their business [4] private.

How you treat people says who you are.

1 Everyone gets them. Even us, once.

2 Say it yourself. No messengers.

3 "Cool, no worries." Then let it go.

4 No screenshots. No group-chat reports.

8

GAME DAY · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Lose WELL

Losing stings. [1] It should.

Shake hands and look up.

Skip the blame. [2]

Watch the tape, [3] find the fix,

then get back to work. [4]

1 Caring is a good sign.

2 Blame costs you the lesson.

3 Ask what beat you.

4 Give yourself one night. Then go.

FEELINGS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

The Spotlight EFFECT

Feel like everyone[1] noticed?
Most people missed[2] it.
The rest forgot[3] by lunch.
Your brain shines a spotlight[4]
that nobody else can see.

1 Tripped, blanked, bad haircut.
2 They're busy worrying about themselves.
3 Can you remember their worst moment?
4 It's a real, studied brain glitch.

SPEAK UP · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Talk to Us ANYTIME

You can tell us anything.[1]
You won't get in trouble
for telling[2] us.
We'd rather know.[3]
Text,[4] talk, or leave a note.

1 School, friends, online, a mistake.
2 The telling part is always safe.
3 Even if it's awkward. Especially then.
4 Easier walking the dog? Say it there.

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GROWTH · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Get Good at AWKWARD

Anything new[1] feels awkward.
That's the price[2] of growing.
The kids who get good[3]
kept going when it felt weird.[4]
Be willing to look like a beginner.

1 New sport, new school, new people.
2 Nobody looks cool on day one.
3 Every senior was a clumsy freshman.
4 Give it three weeks before you judge.

12

GAME DAY · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Coaching Is a GIFT

A coach who corrects[1] you
is investing[2] in you.
Ask one question,[3]
apply[4] it next rep,
and thank them after practice.

1 Silence from a coach is worse.
2 Coaches don't correct lost causes.
3 "What should it look like?"
4 Fix it on the very next rep.

13

SCHOOL · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Advocate for YOURSELF

Nobody knows you're lost [1]

until you say [2] something.

Send the email. [3]

Ask about the grade. [4]

Speaking up for yourself is a skill.

1 Teachers can't read minds.

2 "Can I come in at lunch for help?"

3 Polite. Specific. One question.

4 "What can I do to bring this up?"

14

FRIENDS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Be the UPSTANDER

Someone's getting picked on? [1]

Don't just watch. [2]

Step in, [3] change the subject,

or sit with [4] them later.

Tell an adult if it keeps happening.

1 Hallway, locker room, online.

2 Laughing along counts as joining.

3 "Bro, that's not funny."

4 Checking on them matters most.

15

FEELINGS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Ride the WAVE

Every feeling is a wave.[1]
It builds,[2] it peaks,
and then it passes.[3]
Don't act at the top.[4]
Breathe, wait, then decide.

1 Anger, panic, cringe. All waves.
2 Notice it early: jaw, chest, fists.
3 Usually faster than you'd guess.
4 No texts, no comebacks, no decisions.

16

GROWTH · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Own IT

When you mess up,[1]
skip the excuses.[2]
Say what happened,
fix[3] what you can,
and own[4] the rest.

1 Everyone does. Adults too.
2 "But" cancels everything before it.
3 Make it right before anyone asks.
4 Owning it fast earns trust back.

SPEAK UP · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Listen to UNDERSTAND

Most people listen[1]
just to reply.[2]
Try listening to understand.[3]
Ask one more question.[4]
People open up to good listeners.

1 Phone down. Eyes up.
2 Planning a comeback? You missed it.
3 Say it back: "So you mean..."
4 "What do you mean by that?"

SCHOOL · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Focus MODE

Your brain can't multitask.[1]
Every ping[2] pulls you out.
Phone in another room,[3]
one task[4] at a time,
and the work goes way faster.

1 It switches. Every switch costs you.
2 Getting back in takes way longer.
3 Out of sight, out of mind. Literally.
4 One thing, 25-minute timer.

GAME DAY · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Sleep Is TRAINING

Recovery[1] happens in bed.

Short sleep makes you slower,[2]

weaker, and moody.[3]

Phone out[4] an hour before bed.

Sleep is part of the work.

1 Meet tomorrow? Bed by ten.

2 Slower reactions, more injuries.

3 Tired feels a lot like angry.

4 Charge it in the kitchen.

FRIENDS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Ask FIRST

Ask[1] before you touch,

post, or share[2] their photo.

Only yes[3] means yes.

A no[4] is final.

Respect makes you someone people trust.

1 Hugs, hands, anything. Just ask.

2 Their picture, their call.

3 Silence or "I guess" isn't yes.

4 Don't ask twice. Don't sulk.

SPEAK UP · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Disagree Without DISRESPECT

You can disagree[1]
and still show respect.[2]
Argue the idea,[3]
let them finish[4] first,
Agree to disagree is a win too.

1 With us, teachers, coaches, friends.

2 Tone, eye contact, no eye rolls.

3 Never the person. No name-calling.

4 Then: "I see it differently because..."

GAME DAY · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Control What You CAN

Refs, weather, the other team
aren't yours[1] to control.
Your effort,[2]
your prep,[3]
your response.[4] Own those.

1 Worrying about them wastes energy.

2 Distance? Chase your own PR.

3 Sleep, water, bag packed the night before.

4 Bad heat? Next one's yours.

FEELINGS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Low DAYS

Everyone has low[1] days.
Get outside,[2] eat, sleep,
text a friend back.
Lasts two weeks?[3] Tell us.
Asking[4] for help is strong.

1 Tired, flat, nothing sounds fun.
2 Sun and a walk help. Try it.
3 Or a coach, counselor, or doctor.
4 Anytime, any hour: call a crisis line.

SCHOOL · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Turn It IN

Done beats perfect.[1]
A zero[2] hurts more
than a rough draft ever will.
Check missing[3] work weekly.
Finish the year strong.[4]

1 A B turned in beats an A at home.
2 One zero can drop you a full letter.
3 Sunday night, check the portal.
4 Last week counts as much as the first.

FRIENDS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Friendships CHANGE

Friends drift.[1] It happens.

Nobody has to be the bad guy.[2]

Stay friendly,[3]

make room[4] for new people,

and keep the ones worth keeping.

1 New school, new teams, new interests.

2 Growing apart is normal.

3 Still say hi in the hall.

4 Join something new this fall.

GROWTH · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Boss Your PHONE

Your phone was designed[1]

to keep you scrolling.[2]

So you set the rules:

phones off[3] at dinner,

real life first.[4]

1 Whole teams are paid to hook you.

2 Guess your screen time, then check.

3 Charge it outside your room at night.

4 Homework, practice, people. Then phone.

SPEAK UP · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Tone MATTERS

Texts have no tone.[1]

Reread[2] before you send.

Same with your voice:[3]

how[4] you say it

changes what they hear.

1 "K." can read like you're furious.

2 Would it sound OK out loud?

3 Sarcasm lands harder than you think.

4 Same words, calm voice, new result.

FEELINGS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Talk to Yourself Like a FRIEND

Listen to how you talk[1] to you.

Would you say it to a friend?[2]

Then don't say it to you.

Swap[3] it for something true:

"I can fix[4] this."

1 "I'm so stupid." Catch it.

2 Or a teammate who just messed up?

3 "I'm stupid" becomes "I rushed it."

4 Coach yourself like a good coach would.

FRIENDS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Think Before You POST

Everything[1] can become a screenshot.

Forever.[2]

Before you post or send,[3]

run the grandparent[4] test.

If not, don't.

1 Chats, DMs, "private" stories.

2 Coaches and colleges look.

3 No nudes. Ever. Even "just to one person."

4 Would you show them? Then post it.

GAME DAY · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Lead from ANYWHERE

No captain[1] title needed.

Be first to show up,[2]

last to complain,[3]

loudest for the new guys.[4]

People follow what you do.

1 Leaders get picked after they lead.

2 Early to practice. Every time.

3 Complaining spreads faster than flu.

4 Team: learn every new guy's name.

GROWTH · MIDDLE SCHOOL

When No One's WATCHING

Character[1] is what you do
when nobody's watching.
Finish the last rep,[2]
hand back the extra change,[3]
keep the promise.[4]

1 The real you, no one grading.

2 Empty gym, full effort.

3 Cashier gave too much? Give it back.

4 Do what you said you'd do.

SPEAK UP · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Speak UP

Something's off?[1] Say so.
Confused?[2] Ask the question.
Unfair[3] call? Say it calmly.
Your voice[4] counts.
Use it, or others decide for you.

1 In class, on the team, in the group chat.

2 Half the class is wondering too.

3 Facts first, feelings second.

4 Order your own food. Make the call.

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FRIENDS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Online BLACKMAIL

Someone threatens[1] to share
a photo unless you pay?[2]
Stop[3] replying. Don't delete.
Tell us[4] right away.
It's not your fault. It's fixable.

1 Photos, chats, anything. Real or fake.
2 Never pay. It doesn't stop them.
3 Screenshot the account and messages.
4 You're not in trouble. We'll fix it.

34

GROWTH · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Fail FORWARD

Every miss[1] is data.
Ask what[2] went wrong,
change one thing,[3]
and go again.[4]
That's how failing moves you forward.

1 Bad test, missed shot, lost match.
2 "I rushed" beats "I suck."
3 One fix at a time.
4 Great wrestlers lost a lot first.

SPEAK UP · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Ask, Don't ASSUME

Late[1] reply? Weird look?
Don't fill in the story.[2]
Ask:[3] "Hey, are we good?"
Most drama[4] starts
with someone assuming.

1 Usually busy, tired, or at practice.
2 Your brain picks the worst version.
3 Ten awkward seconds beats a week of drama.
4 Rumors, group chats, "he said."

FEELINGS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Rejection HURTS

Got cut?[1] Got left on read?
Rejection hurts.[2]
It's one no[3] on one day.
Find out[4] what to work on,
and take your next shot.

1 Every athlete gets cut from something.
2 Feel it. Faking fine takes longer.
3 One coach. One person. One moment.
4 Ask, "What would get me there?"

37

SCHOOL · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Plan the WEEK

Sunday[1] night, ten minutes.
List the big stuff,[2]
then block[3] time for it
before practice eats the week.
High school moves fast.[4]

1 Same time every week.
2 Tests, projects, games, meets.
3 Schedule it like a practice.
4 Every grade from here counts.

38

FRIENDS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Have an EXIT PLAN

Bad situation?[1] Want out?
Text us a "pineapple."[2]
We'll call[3] with an "emergency"
and come get you.[4]
Blame us. That's what we're for.

1 Party, bus, sleepover, anywhere.
2 Just the word. Nothing else.
3 "Sorry, family thing. Gotta go."
4 Any time. No questions asked.

39

SCHOOL · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Start UGLY

The hardest part is starting. [1]
So start ugly. [2]
A messy outline, one problem,
a rough first line. [3]
Momentum [4] does the rest.

1 Ten-minute timer. Go.
2 Every good essay was a bad draft first.
3 Write anything. Fix it later.
4 Once you start, you'll keep going.

40

GROWTH · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Compare LESS

Everyone posts [1] their best.
You see your whole [2] day.
So race yesterday's [3] you.
One percent better [4]
is the only race that counts.

1 Nobody posts their worst day.
2 Their highlights vs. your bloopers.
3 Log your own PRs, grades, reps.
4 1% a day adds up fast.

41

SPEAK UP · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Real APOLOGY

A real apology[1] has no "but."
Name exactly[2] what you did,
own how it landed,[3]
say how you'll fix[4] it.
Then give them time.

1 No "if you were offended" either.
2 "I said that in front of everyone."
3 Impact matters more than intent.
4 Then follow through. That's the real part.

42

GROWTH · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Skill Is BUILT

Talent[1] is a head start.
Reps[2] decide the rest.
Every skill you admire[3]
was built on boring[4] days.
Yours is under construction.

1 It only gets you so far.
2 Shots, laps, problems. Count them.
3 Ask how they got good. Listen.
4 Nobody films the boring days.

SCHOOL · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Ask for Help EARLY

Class not clicking? [1]
Get help in week two, [2]
not week nine. [3]
Go to office hours, [4]
ask a friend, or ask us.

1 Writing? Usually one weak skill. Find it.

2 Small gaps are easy to fix early.

3 Late help means relearning a pile.

4 Bring a draft. Ask what to fix first.

GAME DAY · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Next PLAY

Dropped a pass? [1]
Missed a shot? [2]
You get one breath [3]
to be mad about it.
Then it's next play. [4]

1 The next snap is coming. Be ready.

2 Shooters shoot. Take the next one.

3 In, out, flush it.

4 Great players have short memories.

45

FEELINGS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Name It to TAME IT

"I'm fine"[1] isn't a feeling.

Get specific:[2]

Naming it takes the edge[3] off.

Say it[4] to someone you trust,

or write it down.

1 Neither is "whatever."

2 Embarrassed? Disrespected? Left out?

3 Labeling a feeling calms your brain.

4 Even just "I'm stressed about Friday."

46

GAME DAY · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Pressure Is a PRIVILEGE

Nervous[1] before tryouts?

Good. It means it matters.[2]

Pressure only shows up

where you've earned[3] a shot.

So embrace[4] it and compete.

1 Same feeling as excited. Call it that.

2 You only get nervous for big stuff.

3 You put in the work to be here.

4 Tryouts? Hustle is what coaches see.

47

FRIENDS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Pick Your PEOPLE

Your people[1] rub off on you.
Pick friends who lift you up,[2]
be that friend[3] back,
and when the drama starts,
you're allowed to walk away.[4]

1 Who makes you feel most like you?
2 Real friends push you up, not down.
3 Text first. Have their back.
4 Leaving the group chat counts.

48

SPEAK UP · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Say Thanks OUT LOUD

Gratitude[1] you don't say
doesn't count for much.
Thank coaches,[2] teachers, us.
Text[3] the friend who showed up.
Be specific.[4] It hits harder.

1 Name one thing at dinner tonight.
2 Handshake after the season. Every one.
3 "Thanks for having my back today."
4 "Thanks for the ride at 6 a.m."

49

SCHOOL · MIDDLE SCHOOL

The Tough TEACHER

You won't click[1] with everyone.

You can still learn[2] from them.

Stay respectful, do the work.[3]

Still unclear?[4] Ask them.

Then bring us in if it's really unfair.

1 Future bosses will be like this too.

2 Learn what they want. Deliver it.

3 Make your work impossible to criticize.

4 Ask, "What would an A look like?"

50

GAME DAY · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Earn Your ROLE

Not the role[1] you wanted?

Ask Coach what it takes.[2]

Dominate[3] practice,

be great[4] at your job,

and make Coach's choice hard.

1 Every roster needs every role.

2 "What do I need to do to play more?"

3 Every practice is a tryout.

4 Scout team, relay leg, JV. Own it.

51

FEELINGS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Anger Is a SIGNAL

Anger[1] is a signal.

Ask what's under[2] it:

Hit the pause[3] first.

Then say the real thing.[4]

Strength is staying in control.

1 Useful info, loud delivery.

2 Hurt? Embarrassed? Scared? Disrespected?

3 Walk, breathe, shoot around. Then talk.

4 "I felt disrespected when..."

52

FRIENDS · MIDDLE SCHOOL

Sisters FOREVER

Your sister[1] is watching you.

Be the big sister you'd want.[2]

Include[3] her sometimes,

stick up[4] for her always.

Teammates come and go.
Sisters stay.

1 She copies how you talk and act.

2 Who did you look up to at her age?

3 One round of cards counts.

4 Tease at home, defend everywhere else.

Run the TAPE

Athletes review[1] the tape.

Run it back on your year:[2]

what worked,[3]

what didn't,[4]

and what you'll do next.

1 Scroll back to last January.

2 What would you tell January-you?

3 Keep doing it. Write it down.

4 No shame. Just notes.

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53 cards. Cut on the thin lines; each card is 5 by 5 inches.

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51	2026-12-13	Feelings	Anger Is a SIGNAL
52	2026-12-20	Friends	Sisters FOREVER
53	2026-12-27	Growth	Run the TAPE